

Low Sodium Eating

Reducing Salt for Heart Health

Sodium is an essential mineral, but most people consume far more than the body needs. Excess sodium is linked to high blood pressure, which increases the risk of heart disease and stroke. Reducing salt in the diet is one of the most effective dietary changes for heart health.

Where Sodium Comes From

Most dietary sodium does not come from the salt shaker at the table - it comes from processed foods, restaurant meals, and packaged snacks. Bread, sauces like soy sauce and ketchup, pickles, papads, and salty snacks are common sources of hidden sodium.

Tips for Lowering Sodium

Several practical changes can reduce daily sodium intake. Cooking at home with fresh ingredients, using herbs and spices instead of salt for flavor, and reading nutrition labels on packaged foods are all useful strategies.

Suggested Items:

- Flavor with lemon, herbs, and spices instead of salt
- Rinse canned beans and vegetables to reduce salt
- Choose fresh or frozen vegetables over canned
- Limit pickles, papads, and salty snacks
- Read nutrition labels and aim for less than 400 mg sodium per serving
- Cook at home more often to control ingredients

Food	Sodium (mg)	Serving
Pickle	800	1 piece
Papad	500	1 piece
Bread (commercial)	200	1 slice
Soy sauce	1000	1 tbsp
Fresh vegetables	10-30	1 cup

Conclusion

The taste for salt is acquired and can be changed over time. Reducing salt gradually allows the palate to adjust, and food begins to taste better with less salt.